

To new beginnings

IT'S HERE! THE REDESIGN IS FINALLY HERE!

As you can see I'm totally excited. The whole team is kicked about it actually. We're also about to drop dead with exhaustion but that's another story for another time.

This anniversary special issue is one of the biggest we've ever made, and it is also completely revamped in terms of the content strategy and design. Although I can barely contain myself, I'm not going to talk about the Digit redesign here. I figure, who better to talk about that than the veteran of redesigns – Robert. So be sure check out his insight into Digit's new avatar on the next page.

As for me, I'm going to use the redesign as an excuse to talk about some of the more memorable redesigns of the technology world – why some of them succeeded, some failed and some just left us wondering what they were smoking.

A major paradigm shift in the world of tech interfaces came when interaction designers took a conscious decision to move interfaces away from skeuomorphism. For the unfamiliar, skeuomorphism is the belief that objects in the digital world should mimic those of the real world. Hence we have folders, files, trash cans, and floppy disk icons in our UIs. Referencing the real world so literally has its benefits – familiarity and easing the learning curve – but it also brings inefficiencies and restrictions. Why spend precious real estate and resources recreating true-to-life shadows, gradients, and all the bells and whistles? Besides, a lot of people believe that the recent generation that has grown up with technology doesn't need these metaphorical training wheels. They couldn't care less if the save icon had a big S on it or the picture of a floppy disk, because they don't know what a floppy disk is to begin with.

When iOS 7 came out, Jony Ive spoke about the benefits of moving away from skeuomorphism. People were anyway used to touching glass instead of buttons, now those elements underneath the glass also needed a revamp. Stripping the interface of physical world references like bevelling also led to what we now know of as flat design. And guess what, flat designs are not just easier on the eyes, they are easier to render too.

Around the same time another tech giant went with a redesign of their own. Microsoft decided to completely revamp the way their desktop interface works by implementing the "metro" UI. They later dropped the name, and called it Modern UI. Call it whatever you want the redesign was hailed as a colossal disaster. While iOS didn't get rid of skeuomorphism – it only diminished it – Windows on the other hand, changed the entire way people were used to interacting with their favourite operating system. The UI became more geared towards touch, rather than mouse input. The beloved Start button disappeared. Making your users get out of their comfort zone (in incremental steps) is good every now and then but forcing them to think of their desktops as tablets is just absurd. Naturally the redesign failed. Microsoft did this strange stopgap thing with Windows 8.1 in which they allowed you to boot directly into "desktop mode" and brought back a weird version of the start menu back. It took another version till they finally got things right again.

If there's any learning to be taken away from the two contrasting redesigns, it is that a successful redesign then can't deviate too much from what is familiar to legacy users. And secondly it needs to take into account a lot of feedback from existing users. Heck, if the budget exists, focus group market research and beta testers isn't a bad idea either.

If you'll notice, as you browse through the magazine, the Digit that you love is still there within the pages. However, there's a new attitude, presentation and style.

Some of you will also notice that we've been subtly taking in a lot of feedback from you guys by way of surveys and generally keeping an ear out for criticism and suggestions. Hopefully we've done justice to this redesign, and if not we can always have an 8.1 and eventually jump to a version 10. **ri**



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